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Private hospital chains are adding thousands of beds across the country. Evidence on whether those investments are translating into consistently better clinical care remains limited

Hospital executives say scale can improve quality rather than dilute it. Jose points to Manipal's integration of 31 acquired hospitals under a common clinical and operating framework as evidence that large networks can standardise care.

Dr. Seth says expanding into Tier-II and Tier-III cities will improve India's healthcare landscape if quality travels with infrastructure. "The encouraging part is that small towns, where I never imagined a cath lab could exist, now have well-equipped facilities run by well-trained DM cardiologists," he says.

"India's healthcare landscape stands at an inflection point. Rising incomes, health awareness, demographic shifts, insurance penetration and the burden of chronic disease are reshaping demand and expectations. In this context, hospitals are no longer merely centres of treatment; they are essential social and economic infrastructure, shaping productivity, dignity and quality of life of a nation," says Suneeta Reddy, Managing Director, Apollo Hospitals.

For Dr Seth, profits are necessary, but the defining measure is the value hospitals create for patients. "Profit is necessary because healthcare requires investment.

Profiteering is what is wrong," he says. He argues that India needs stricter audits, outcome-based reimbursement and greater emphasis on hospital readmissions as measures of care.

DOCTOR ENTREPRENEURS

India's hospital boom is not being driven by capital alone. Behind many of the country's largest healthcare institutions are doctors who stepped beyond clinical practice to build some of India's most successful hospital enterprises.

From Dr. Prathap C. Reddy of Apollo Hospitals and Dr Naresh Trehan of Medanta to Dr. Devi Shetty of Narayana Health, these physician-entrepreneurs have helped redefine organised healthcare in India. They built institutions that have expanded access to specialised care, attracted global investment and transformed healthcare into one of the country's fastest-growing industries.

Read the next story, "*The Doctorpreneurs*," to find out how these doctorpreneurs turned medical expertise into enduring healthcare businesses. **BT**

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